

[Lesson 1](#): “Introduction to the Doctrine and Covenants and Church History” (D&C 1; [Our Heritage](#))

Purpose: To help us understand the Doctrine and Covenants and Church history and their place in the dispensation of the fullness of times.

†1. Revelation Comes Anew †2. Roger Williams †3. President Ezra Taft Benton †4. Capstone
Capstone on the [Salt Lake Temple](#), Images: [Temple](#). Click on “More Photos” [Angel Moroni](#) on the
capstone of the Bern Switzerland Temple, Salt Lake Temple [Capstone Ceremony](#)

1. The revelations in the Doctrine and Covenants address the needs of our day.

- Explanatory Intro. 3rd para. “The book of Doctrine and Covenants ...”
- What passages in the Doctrine and Covenants have been especially helpful or meaningful to you?
- Explanatory Intro. 6th para. “These sacred revelations ...”
 - Explanatory Intro. 8th para. “In the revelations ...”
- What are some of the doctrines of the gospel that are explained in the Doctrine and Covenants?

2. The Lord authored the preface to the Doctrine and Covenants. (D&C 1)

“On 1 November 1831, the Prophet Joseph Smith presided at a special conference of elders, held in Hiram, Ohio. Those in attendance decided to compile some of the revelations the Prophet had received and publish them in a book called the Book of Commandments. Following the first session of this conference, the Lord signified His approval for the publication by giving Joseph Smith a revelation that He called “my preface unto the book of my commandments” (D&C 1:). This revelation is now section 1 of the Doctrine and Covenants.” (*Lesson Manual*) †5.
President Benson

- D&C 1:17-28 “Wherefore, I the Lord, knowing the calamity which should come upon the inhabitants of the earth ...”

According to these verses, what are some of the purposes of the revelations?

What are the promises?

- D&C 1:37-38 “Search these commandments, ... and the prophecies and the promises... shall all be fulfilled.”
- D&C 18:34-36 “These words are not of men nor of man, but of me ... (36) you have heard my voice”.

3. This course will discuss major events of the dispensation of the fullness of times.

- [D&C 112:30-32](#) “For unto you, the Twelve ... is the power of this priesthood given, for the last days”.

†6. The Prophet Joseph Smith

Why or how is our dispensation different from any of the previous ones?

What are some of the blessings and responsibilities of living in this dispensation?

“This dispensation can be divided into six historical periods.” (*Lesson Manual*)

- | | |
|---------------------------|--------------|
| • New York Period | 1820-1830 |
| • Ohio-Missouri Period | 1831-1838 |
| • Nauvoo Period | 1839-1846 |
| • Pioneering the West | 1846-1898 |
| • Expansion of the Church | 1899-1950 |
| • The Worldwide Church | 1951-present |

“Many of the important events in these six historical periods are summarized in “Church History Chronology” in the *Class Member Study Guide*.” (*Lesson Manual*)

Briefly review these events: Which of these events have particular significance to you?

4. We can each help to move forward this great latter-day work.

“We are not here on earth at this time by accident. We have been sent by God to help build His kingdom in this last dispensation.” (*Lesson Manual*) †7. President Ezra Taft Benson †8. President Gordon B. Hinckley

What are some challenges that are presented by the Church’s tremendous growth?

What are some examples of the Church’s efforts to meet these challenges?

Are we keeping pace and doing our part as families and individuals? †9. Norma B. Williams

What can we each do individually and in our families to help move forward the Lord’s great latter-day work?

Next Week: Lesson 2: “Behold, I Am Jesus Christ, the Savior of the World; See [L2 Study Guide](#). † •
(You can download a free LDS Institute Manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#)).)

†1. **Revelation Comes Anew:** “After the death of Jesus and the Apostles, the priesthood power was no longer available to the people in the Old World and the Great Apostasy set in. The world was left with what revelations had been written and passed on. Later these were collected and placed with writings from the ancient prophets to form the Old and New Testaments. One cannot underestimate the impact and value of the Bible in the history and development of Christianity. With no additional scriptural revelations being given to the people in general, it is not surprising that soon the Bible was the only source of God’s word. One creed, for example, states that the Bible contains ‘the whole counsel of God,’ and another says, ‘Holy Scripture containeth all things necessary to salvation’ (Backman, *American Religions*, 449. Cited in [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#) 1).

†2. **Roger Williams** a pastor of the very first Baptist Church in America, remained “a Baptist only briefly. He remained with the little church in Providence only a few months. He became convinced that the ordinances, having been lost in the Apostasy [when Christianity became the official religion of the Roman Empire], could not be validly restored without a special divine commission. He declared: ‘There is no regularly constituted church of Christ on earth, nor any person qualified to administer any church ordinances; nor can there be until new apostles are sent by the Great Head of the Church for whose coming I am seeking.’

He never again affiliated himself with any church, but remained deeply religious and active in preaching and praying. He looked forward to the time when Christ would send a new apostle to restore the church, but in the meantime, he would be a “witness” to Christianity.” (Wikipedia: [Roger Williams](#))

†3. **President Ezra Taft Benson:** “The Doctrine and Covenants brings men to Christ’s kingdom, even The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, ‘the only true and living church upon the face of the whole earth’ [D&C 1:30]...

“The Book of Mormon is the ‘keystone’ of our religion, and the Doctrine and Covenants is the capstone, with continuing latter-day revelation. The Lord has placed His stamp of approval on both the keystone and the capstone” (“[The Book of Mormon and the Doctrine and Covenants](#),” *Ensign*, May 1987, 83).

†4. **Capstone:** “One of the finishing or protective stones that form the top of an exterior masonry wall or building” (Wikipedia: [Capstone](#))

†5. **President Ezra Taft Benson:** “The Doctrine and Covenants is the only book in the world that has a preface written by the Lord Himself. In that preface He declares to the world that His voice is unto all men (see v.2), that the coming of the Lord is nigh (see v. 12), and

that the truths found in the Doctrine and Covenants will all be fulfilled (see vs. 37-38)” (“[The Gift of Modern Revelation](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1986, 79).

†6. **The Prophet Joseph Smith:** “Prophets, priests and kings ... have looked forward with joyful anticipation to the day in which we live; and fired with heavenly and joyful anticipations they have sung and written and prophesied of this our day; but they died without the sight; we are the favored people that God has made choice of to bring about the Latter-day glory; it is left for us to see, participate in and help to roll forward the Latter-day glory, ‘the dispensation of the fullness of times’” (*Teachings of the Prophet Joseph Smith*, sel. Joseph Fielding Smith [1976], 231).

†7. **President Ezra Taft Benson:** “There has never been more expected of the faithful in such a short period of time as there is of us” (Marvin J. Ashton, “[Stalwart and Brave We Stand](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1989, 36).

†8. **President Gordon B. Hinckley:** “This is a season of a thousand opportunities. It is ours to grasp and move forward. What a wonderful time it is for each of us to do his or her small part in moving the work of the Lord on to its magnificent destiny” (“[Look to the Future](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1997, 67).

†9. **Norma B. Williams, Redwood City, CA:** “Recently, I attended a wonderful Relief Society lesson ... It was pointed out that people who join the Church there are often ostracized by family and friends. After the discussion, a lovely sister said, ‘Perhaps I shouldn’t say this, but the lesson made me think of it.’ She recounted how she had joined the Church recently and that her daughter who moved to a community of members of the Church felt ostracized there because she is *not* a member of the Church. She feels that her neighbors were friendly at first, then dropped her when they learned that she was not a member, and not eagerly interested in coming out to Church. She feels that she even has trouble getting baby-sitters because she is not a member. Her daughter was invited to Primary, but felt such little friendship that she did not want to go again.” (“[Comment: The Non-Mormon Neighbor](#),” *Ensign*, Feb. 1977, 88)

Recommended Reading:

George A. Horton, Jr., “[‘Be Ye Also Ready’: The Amazing Christian Escape from the A.D. 70 Destruction of Jerusalem](#),” *Ensign*, Oct. 1987, 2.
President Ezra Taft Benson, “[The Gift of Modern Revelation](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1986, 79.

Visit www.stephenmbird.com/library/gospel-doctrine †

Further Enrichment Resources:

D&C 1:4. "And the voice of warning shall be unto all people".

Elder Boyd K. Packer: "How could there be such a terrible destruction with such little loss of life? ... Because they were warned! They didn't have very long, but they were warned; and every man who was warned, warned his neighbor....

"What about the six that drowned? One of them was just below the dam and had no choice. Two of them wouldn't believe the warning until it was too late. They later found them both in their car, but they hadn't heeded the warning. Three of them went back to get some material possessions, and they lost their lives.

"But it was a miracle of tremendous proportion... [One expert said that there should have been about fifty-three hundred people killed. But there were only six. The others had been warned, and they had heeded the warning. (Note: This bracketed text is found only in the book.)]

"Now I see a great similarity in what is happening in the world, a great tidal wave of evil and wickedness in the world. It just seeps around us and gets deeper and deeper. Our lives are in danger. Our property is in danger. Our freedoms are in danger, and yet we casually go about our work unable to understand that it behooves every man that has been warned to warn his neighbor....

"[We have been] warned by a prophet. Will [we] heed the warning, or will [we] be as those six in Idaho who thought the warning was not for them?" (*That All May Be Edified* [1982], 220-21, 223. See Old Testament: Gospel Doctrine Teacher's Manual [Lesson 43: Shepherds of Israel](#). Do a Google page search for "Packer".)

More Details of the Teton Dam flood:

David Mitchell: "... the helicopter gently snuggled down on the mud-caked field on the edge of the small town... Doors opened and out stepped President Spencer W. Kimball... As he was driven around the broken streets, he saw houses wrenched from their foundations, cars nestled in trees, road surfaces ruptured and scattered, downed power and telephone lines, houses turned into kindling, buildings blasted open as if by a bomb, walls that had been stripped of their brick facing, and mud-covered prized possessions everywhere. The president was in what was left of Sugar City, one of several Idaho communities ravaged when the 307-foot high Teton Dam burst on Saturday, June 5.

"The 250,000 acre-feet of water that broke through the dam flooded and wrecked thousands of homes along a 65-mile course, leaving 7,000 Saints homeless and destroying all of the community of Wilford, and much of Sugar City and Rexburg. Surrounding communities received a mud bath, and some 30,000 acres of farmland were ruined...

"Approximately 3,000 homes had been ruined by the floodwaters, along with many businesses, schools, and much farmland. In some areas the force of the water had stripped the earth down four, five, and six feet to bare rock, while in other areas the water had left behind a layer of rock and gravel up to two feet deep across the once arable land."

...
"For most people, the fury of the flood came as a complete surprise. Residents of Sugar City and Rexburg thought that by the time the erupting water reached their communities it would be perhaps two or three feet high. But they had to scramble for their lives.

Gordon Clark of Sugar City was on a rise overlooking the dam when the water broke through. "The canyon leading from the dam is forty feet deep and the water was up over the edge. By the time it reached the mouth of the canyon it must have topped fifty feet."

"That wall of water hit the community of Wilford and washed it off the map. Not only were houses smashed from their foundations, but the foundations were ripped up and washed away as well.

"As the water reached Sugar City it spread out, but it was still a frightening fifteen feet high and moving fast. Sugar City resident Norman Gage saw it coming. "It looked like a rolling wall coming at us. We took off and headed for Ricks College."

...
"When the dam broke an evacuation alert went out over radio and television and law enforcement officials drove up and down streets and country roads telling people to leave for higher ground. Approximately 95 percent of the population in the area is Latter-day Saint, and ward members ran to warn their neighbors. Many failed to heed the warning until the water could be seen and heard.

...
"From Sugar City, the wall of water raced on to the north side of Rexburg, where it hit Hibbard before moving into the city and the downtown area.

"We had about three hours to prepare here in Rexburg after the dam burst, but there was a lot of scepticism," according to Ricks College security officer Jack Reinwand. "I know I thought that we might have one or two feet of water, and the downtown businessmen were preparing to keep that much out of their stores and offices. But Bill Sessions, another security officer, and I drove downtown and there was a tidal wave coming at us."

"As the water raged through Hibbard it demolished a new housing division, washed away a trailer court, cut away chunks of road to a depth of four feet, and established new riverbeds. As it struck Rexburg, it tore through a sawmill and the trees it picked up acted as battering rams throughout the city. Water, mud, and debris swirled into homes and stores. Many businessmen lost their merchandise and their display cases and had bloated cattle left in their stead.

"Brother and Sister Martell Grover of the Rexburg First Ward owned a jewelry and watchmaking business on

Rexburg's Main Street. They lost everything. 'We had a dead calf between our house and its foundation, and a dead cow in our backyard,' said Brother Grover. ['We've lost our home and our business; there's nothing to salvage.'](#)

"'We came into the world naked, and I guess that we're being shown that we can go out that way too.'" [At Ricks College, on higher ground, people watched the floodwaters destroy Rexburg, Idaho.]

"One of those who watched was [Bishop Melvin Richardson](#) of the Ammon Fifth Ward, Idaho Falls Idaho Ammon Stake, who was on news assignment for a local television station.

"'I saw one man,' he recalls, ['who was sitting on the hood of his car using binoculars to watch the wave of water move through the town. He told me he was looking at his house and when I asked him how it was doing he said, "Fine. It's just going round the bend." It was a brick house and we estimated that it traveled a mile in about three minutes before coming to a halt.](#)

"'That water came through and hit a line of trees and they just went down. A haystack with hundreds of bales of hay in it just exploded on impact.'" "News of the Church: [Thousands of Saints Left Homeless by Idaho Flood](#), by David Mitchell, Assistant Editor," *Ensign*, Aug. 1976,).

Eldon Linschoten, Manager, Church Photography Department: "On the fifth of June, [80 billion gallons of water poured through a gap in the Teton Dam—in twelve minutes](#). Farmers and townspeople in Wilford, Sugar City, and Rexburg rushed from their homes to high ground. They turned and watched as a wall of water swept away their homes, their farms, the food supply, their barns, their livestock, their shops, their cars—and left behind mud, sand, animal carcasses, and a grim future. ("News of the Church: [Personal Impressions of the Photographer: Here's How I See It](#)," *Ensign*, Oct. 1976)

Lynn Tilton, Associate Editor: "Minutes later [10,000 people standing on the campus hill watched the flood waters tear into their community](#). Huge logs from a sawmill on the northeast edge of town battered through town, striking houses, businesses, and even airplanes at the airport. [In one section all but eight homes in a 55-home trace were moved from their foundations](#), many smashed apart. More than 200 businesses were ruined as the waters swept through town on the way to Idaho Falls, Blackfoot, and other communities in the Snake River Valley. ("[Breaking Point: Teton Dam Disaster in Idaho](#)," *New Era*, Sept. 1976, 48)

D&C 1:15. "They have strayed from mine ordinances".

Beverly A. Pitts, the wife of Mission President Neil E. Pitts (Utah Provo Mission), said, "President Pitts and I are converts. He was showering and received an overwhelming spirit telling him he needed to be baptized."

When he told her, she reminded him he'd been baptized in the Presbyterian church.

He said, ["I know, but for some reason it doesn't count."](#)

So he began to learn about other churches. Two sisters knocked at the door and he said, "I've been looking for you."

They sat down and he said, "Can you tell me in a few sentences why I should listen to you?"

One sister said, "I can tell you in one word, ['Authority'](#)."

As the sisters taught, Sister Pitts started to cry and her husband asked, "What's the matter? Why are you crying?"

She said, "I know what they're teaching is true."

He said, "I know it's true too."

Following Sister Pitts talk, President Pitt went to the speakers stand and added more to the story.

He said, "As we were getting ready to be baptized I called my brother and said, 'I think you should know we're getting baptized.'"

His brother said, "No way! We're getting baptized too."

He told the young men in the audience, ["You will see miracles and come home rock solid."](#)

His daughter said, "Dad, I *don't want* to serve a mission."

He said, "You don't have to."

"Dad ..." She and her father repeated this three times.

Then she said, *"But I have to*. I received a witness. I've been called."

Later President Pitt quoted President Dieter F. Uchtdorf: "It is not enough merely to speak of Jesus Christ or proclaim that we are His disciples. It is not enough to surround ourselves with symbols of our religion. [Discipleship is not a spectator sport](#). We cannot expect to experience the blessings of faith by standing inactive on the sidelines any more than we can experience the benefits of health by sitting on a sofa watching sporting events on television and giving advice to the athletes. And yet for some, 'Spectator discipleship' is a preferred if not a primary way of worshipping." ("[The Way of the Disciple](#)," *Ensign*, May 2009, 77 (75-78)). (From my notes of Grove Creek Stake Conference and Father's Day, Sunday, June 19, 2011.)